

Electrostatics

Problem 2.1

- (a) Twelve equal charges, q , are situated at the corners of a regular 12-sided polygon (for instance, one on each numeral of a clock face). What is the net force on a test charge Q at the center?
- (b) Suppose one of your 12 q s is removed (the one at “6 o’clock”). What is the force on Q ? Explain your reasoning carefully.
- (c) Now 13 equal charges q , are placed at the corners of a regular 13-sided polygon. What is the force on a test charge Q at the center?
- (d) If one of the 13 q s is removed, what is the force on Q ? Explain your reasoning.

Solution:

(a) Due to the symmetry, the net force on a test charge at the center is zero. This is because each opposite charge q on the 12-sided polygon cancel each others force at the center. The force from the charge at 1 o’clock cancels the force from the charge at 7 o’clock, etc.

(b) If the charge at 6 o’clock is removed, the net force on a test charge at the center is

$$\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{qQ}{r^2}$$

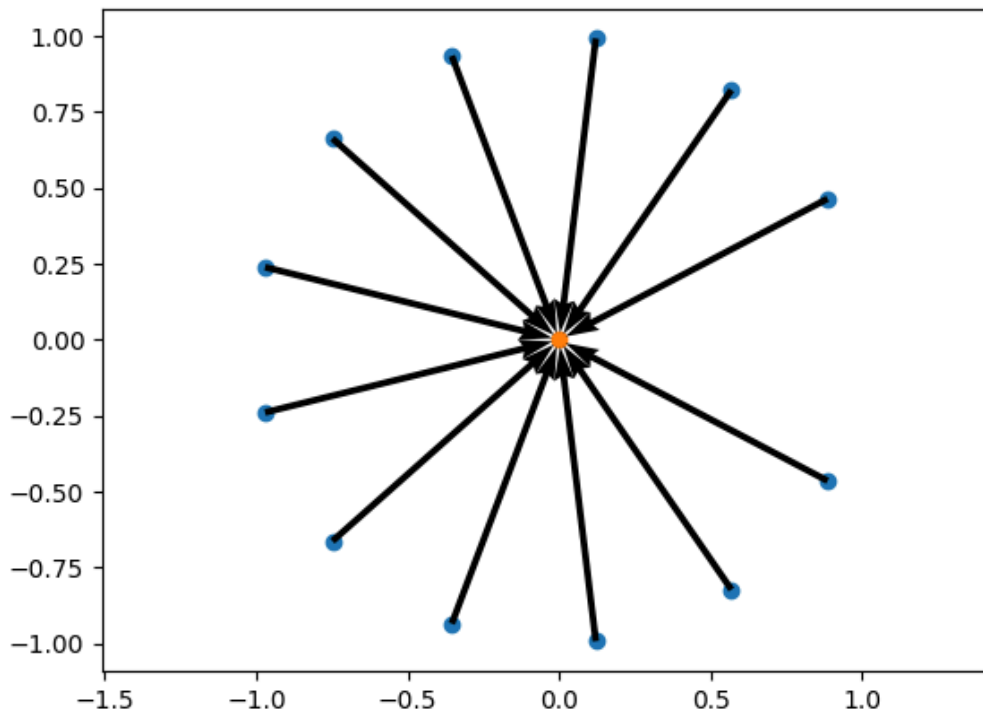
directed straight down (straight up) if the charge q and the test charge Q are both positive or both negative (if they are positive/negative or negative/positive respectively).

(c) Again, due to symmetry, the net force at the center is zero.

(d) The force on the center would again be

$$\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{qQ}{r^2}$$

directed towards the removed charge (or opposite direction, if the charges q and the test charge Q are of opposite signs). This can either be explained by simply adding a charge of opposite sign at the removed charge, or by the same idea as in (b), from the following image



All vertical components of the forces cancel, giving the total force as the sum of the individual charges:

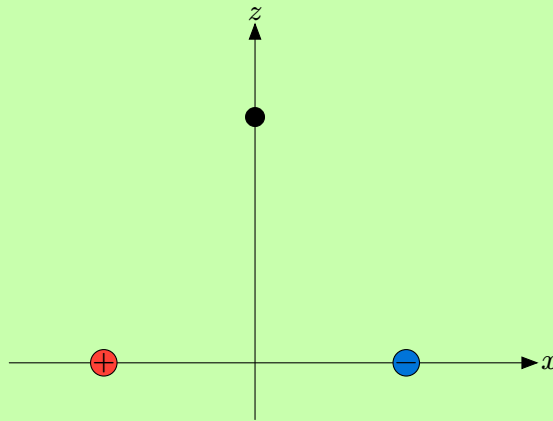
$$\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{qQ}{r^2} \sum_{k=1}^{13} \cos\left(\frac{2\pi k}{13}\right) = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{qQ}{r^2} \hat{r} \text{ with } \hat{r} \text{ pointing towards the right}$$

□

Problem 2.2

Find the electric field (magnitude and direction) a distance z above the mid-point between equal and opposite charges ($\pm q$), a distance d apart.

Solution:



The electric field from a point charge is given by

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q}{r^2} \hat{\mathbf{r}}$$

where r is the distance between the charge and the field point and $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ is the unit separation vector from the charge to the field point. The field at our measurement point will have no vertical (z -directed) component since the positive charge will create a field in the positive z -direction with the same magnitude that the negative charge will create a field in the negative z -direction. Therefore the total field will be directed towards $+x$ with a magnitude twice that of what the positive charge creates. The separation vector magnitude becomes

$$r = \sqrt{z^2 + \left(\frac{d}{2}\right)^2}$$

and

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{r} &= \frac{d}{2} \hat{\mathbf{x}} \\ \downarrow \\ \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{\mathbf{r}}{r} = \frac{d}{2r} \hat{\mathbf{x}} \end{aligned}$$

resulting in the total electric field from both charges

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{qd}{\sqrt{z^2 + \left(\frac{d}{2}\right)^2}^3} \hat{\mathbf{x}}$$

□

Problem 2.3

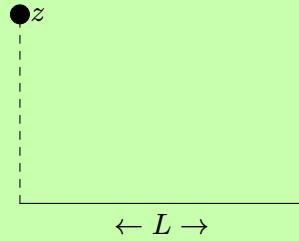
Find the electric field a distance z above one end of a straight line segment of length L that carries a uniform line charge λ . Check that your formula is consistent with what you would expect for the case $z \gg L$.

Solution:

The electric field from a continuous line charge distribution is given by

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int \frac{\lambda(\mathbf{r}')}{r^2} d\mathbf{l}'$$

The setup is shown in the figure below



The separation vector $\mathbf{r}$ becomes

$$-x\hat{\mathbf{x}} + z\hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

which gives

$$\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{-x\hat{\mathbf{x}} + z\hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}}$$

This means our integral becomes, since λ is constant,

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^L \frac{-x\hat{\mathbf{x}} + z\hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}^3} dx$$

The following standard integrals will be used in the calculations:

$$\int \frac{1}{\sqrt{x^2 + a^2}^3} dx = \frac{1}{a^2} \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + a^2}}$$

$$\int \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + a^2}} dx = -\frac{1}{\sqrt{x^2 + a^2}}$$

Starting with the x -component gives

$$\begin{aligned} E_x &= -\frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^L \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}^3} dx = -\frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left[-\frac{1}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}} \right]_0^L = \\ &= \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left(\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{\sqrt{L^2 + z^2}} \right) \end{aligned}$$

And the z -component

$$\begin{aligned} E_z &= \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^L \frac{z}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}^3} dx = \frac{\lambda z}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left[\frac{1}{z^2} \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + z^2}} \right]_0^L = \\ &= \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0 z} \left(\frac{L}{\sqrt{L^2 + z^2}} \right) \end{aligned}$$

The electric field is then

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left(\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{\sqrt{L^2 + z^2}} \right) \hat{\mathbf{x}} + \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0 z} \left(\frac{L}{\sqrt{L^2 + z^2}} \right) \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

In the case that $z \gg L$, we get

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left(\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{z} \right) \hat{\mathbf{x}} + \frac{\lambda}{4\pi\epsilon_0 z} \left(\frac{L}{z} \right) \hat{\mathbf{z}} = \frac{\lambda L}{4\pi\epsilon_0 z^2} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

which is of the same form as the field at a point z from a point charge of magnitude λL . $\square$

Problem 2.4

Find the electric field a distance z above the center of a square loop (side length d) carrying a uniform line charge λ .

Solution:

Due to the symmetry, it is enough to calculate the contribution from one of the sides, and multiplying this result by 4. Only the z -component will be calculated since the x - and y -components will cancel.

Starting with determining the separation vector for one of the sides ($x : -\frac{a}{2} \rightarrow \frac{a}{2}, y = \frac{a}{2}$)

$$\mathbf{r} = x\hat{\mathbf{x}} + \frac{a}{2}\hat{\mathbf{y}} + z\hat{\mathbf{z}} = z\hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

and the magnitude

$$r = \sqrt{x^2 + \left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2}$$

gives

$$\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{z\hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{x^2 + \left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2}}$$

Using these, the electric field is given by

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_{-\frac{a}{2}}^{\frac{a}{2}} \frac{\lambda z \hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{x^2 + \left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2}^3} dx$$

$$E_x = \frac{\lambda z}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_{-\frac{a}{2}}^{\frac{a}{2}} \frac{1}{\sqrt{x^2 + \left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2}^3} dx = \frac{\lambda z}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left[\frac{x}{\left(\left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2\right) \sqrt{x^2 + \left(\frac{a}{2}\right)^2 + z^2}} \right]_{-\frac{a}{2}}^{\frac{a}{2}} =$$

$$= \frac{\lambda z}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{a}{\left(\left[\frac{a^2}{4} + z^2\right] \sqrt{\frac{a^2}{4} + z^2}\right)}$$

Multiplying this by four gives the final result

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{\lambda z a}{\pi\epsilon_0 \left(\frac{a^2}{4} + z^2\right) \sqrt{\frac{a^2}{4} + z^2}} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

□

Problem 2.5

Find the electric field a distance z above the center of a circular loop of radius r that carries a uniform line charge λ .

Solution:

Using cylindrical coordinates, the separation vector $\mathbf{r}$ is

$$\mathbf{r} = r\hat{\mathbf{r}} + z\hat{\mathbf{z}} = [\text{symmetry}] = z\hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

and the magnitude

$$r = \sqrt{r^2 + z^2}$$

gives

$$\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{z}{\sqrt{r^2 + z^2}} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

The circular loop at radius r has the integral form $\int_0^{2\pi} r d\theta$. The integral that gives the resulting electric field is

$$\mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{\lambda z \hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{r^2 + z^2}^3} r d\theta = \frac{\lambda z r}{2\epsilon_0 \sqrt{r^2 + z^2}^3} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

□

Problem 2.6

Find the electric field a distance z above the center of a flat circular disk of radius R that carries a uniform surface charge σ . What does your formula give in the limit $R \rightarrow \infty$? Also check the case $z \gg R$.

Solution:

The electric field for a surface charge is given by

$$\mathbf{E}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_{\mathcal{S}} \frac{\sigma(\mathbf{r}')}{r^2} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \, da'$$

Our disk is given by the cylindrical coordinates s and ϕ

$$s : 0 \rightarrow R, \quad \phi : 0 \rightarrow 2\pi$$

The integration is

$$da' = s \, ds \, d\phi$$

The separation vector is

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{r} &= z\hat{\mathbf{z}} - s\hat{\mathbf{s}} \\ &\downarrow \\ r &= \sqrt{z^2 + s^2} \\ &\downarrow \\ \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{z\hat{\mathbf{z}} - s\hat{\mathbf{s}}}{\sqrt{z^2 + s^2}} \end{aligned}$$

Due to the symmetry of the problem, the s -dependence will add up to zero, so we will ignore the s -component in the unit separation vector. The electric field at the z -axis is then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{E}(z) &= \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^R \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{\sigma z \hat{\mathbf{z}}}{\sqrt{z^2 + s^2}^3} s \, ds \, d\phi = \\ &= \frac{2\pi z \sigma \hat{\mathbf{z}}}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \int_0^R \frac{s}{\sqrt{z^2 + s^2}^3} \, ds = \frac{2\pi z \sigma \hat{\mathbf{z}}}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \left[-\frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2 + s^2}} \right]_0^R = \\ &= \frac{z\sigma}{2\epsilon_0} \left[\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2 + R^2}} \right] \hat{\mathbf{z}} \end{aligned}$$

In the limit that $R \rightarrow \infty$, the electric field is given by

$$\frac{z\sigma}{2\epsilon_0} \left[\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{R} \right] \hat{\mathbf{z}} = \frac{\sigma}{2\epsilon_0} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

When $z \gg R$, naively setting the square root term to $\frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2+R^2}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2}} = \frac{1}{z}$ would give the (somewhat) incorrect result zero. The square root expression needs to be Taylor expanded with the rule (assuming $|x| \ll 1$)

$$(1+x)^n = 1 + nx + \frac{n(n-1)}{2!}x^2 + \dots$$

Rewriting the square root term

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2+R^2}} &= \frac{1}{z} \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+\frac{R^2}{z^2}}} = \frac{1}{z} \left(1 + \frac{R^2}{z^2}\right)^{-\frac{1}{2}} \\ &\downarrow \\ \frac{1}{\sqrt{z^2+R^2}} &\approx \frac{1}{z} \left(1 - \frac{1}{2} \frac{R^2}{z^2}\right) \end{aligned}$$

which gives the electric field

$$\frac{z\sigma}{2\epsilon_0} \left[\frac{1}{z} - \frac{1}{z} \left(1 - \frac{1}{2} \frac{R^2}{z^2}\right) \right] \hat{\mathbf{z}} = \frac{z\sigma}{2\epsilon_0} \frac{1}{2} \frac{R^2}{z^3} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

Expressing the charge density and the radius in terms of the total charge Q would give $Q = \sigma\pi R^2$ which results in the electric field

$$\mathbf{E}(z) = \frac{Q}{4\pi\epsilon_0 z^2} \hat{\mathbf{z}}$$

□

Problem 2.7

Problem 2.8

Problem 2.9

Suppose the electric field in some region is found to be $\mathbf{E} = kr^3\mathbf{r}$, in spherical coordinates (k is some constant).

- Find the charge density ρ .
- Find the total charge contained in a sphere of radius R , centered at the origin. (Do it two different ways.)

Solution:

(a) Gauss's law in differential form is

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} = \frac{1}{\epsilon_0} \rho \rightarrow \rho = \epsilon_0 \nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}$$

The divergence of $\mathbf{E}$ is

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} = \nabla \cdot kr^3 \hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{1}{r^2} \frac{\partial}{\partial r} (r^2 kr^3) = 5kr^2$$

so the charge density ρ is

$$\rho = \epsilon_0 5kr^2$$

(b) The total charge Q can be obtained in two ways; integrating the charge density over the volume, or integrating the electric field over the bounding surface.

Integrating the charge density over the volume of a sphere with radius R gives

$$\begin{aligned} Q &= \int_V \epsilon_0 5kr^2 r^2 \sin \theta \, dr \, d\theta \, d\phi \\ &\quad \downarrow \\ 5k\epsilon_0 \int_0^R r^4 \left(\int_0^\pi \sin \theta \left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi \right) d\theta \right) dr &= \\ = 20k\pi\epsilon_0 \int_0^R r^4 \, dr &= \boxed{Q = 4\pi\epsilon_0 kR^5} \end{aligned}$$

Integrating the electric field over the bounding surface of the sphere with radius R gives

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{Q}{\epsilon_0} &= \int_S kr^3 r^2 \sin \theta \, d\theta \, d\phi \\ &\quad \downarrow \\ Q &= \epsilon_0 kR^5 \int_0^\pi \sin \theta \left(\int_0^{2\pi} d\phi \right) d\theta \rightarrow \boxed{Q = 4\pi\epsilon_0 kR^5} \end{aligned}$$

□

Problem 2.10

A charge q sits at the back corner of a cube, as shown in the figure. What is the flux of $\mathbf{E}$ through the shaded side?

Solution:

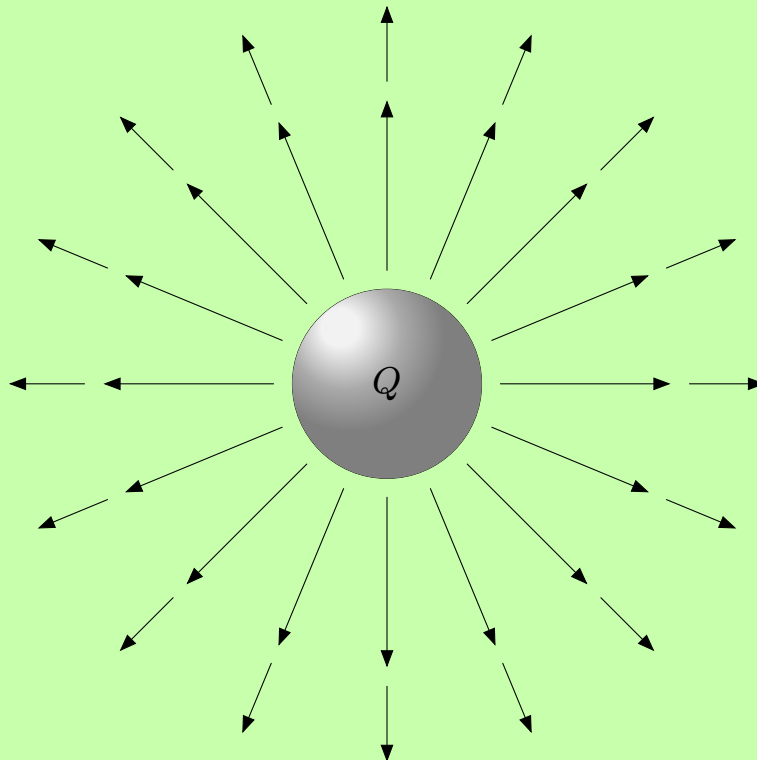
Adding 7 cubes to totally enclose the charge gives a total of 24 faces that the flux is passing through. This means that the flux of this one surface is $1/24$ of the total flux given by the charge q .

$$[\text{Flux through the shaded surface}] = \frac{q}{24\epsilon_0}$$

□

Problem 2.11

Draw a field-line diagram for a uniformly charged solid sphere.

Solution:

□

Problem 2.12

Problem 2.13

Problem 2.14

Problem 2.15

Problem 2.16

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